

Case Study

May 2026

Strengthening Fayda:

Ethiopia's improvement
journey through the Digital
ID Assessment



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Introduction

Launched in 2021 by the National ID Program (NIDP), Fayda is the cornerstone of Ethiopia's digital transformation strategy, with the ambition of issuing unique digital IDs to more than 90 million citizens and residents by 2028 and unlocking opportunities for people, government, and businesses alike. Ethiopia's approach to building Fayda has focused on strengthening local capacity while tailoring globally recognized standards to the local context, always with an eye to the rights of Ethiopia's citizens and residents. Sustaining this work requires coordinated focus, continuous evaluation, and iterative improvement – each central to achieving meaningful progress.

In early 2025, NIDP leveraged the [Digital ID Assessment](#), developed by the Digital Impact Alliance (DIAL), as part of its commitment to refine the Fayda ID system. The self-assessment offered a structured way to evaluate Fayda's design and processes – surfacing [where the system was strong and where improvements were needed](#) to support future growth and sharpen intended outcomes. Following the results, NIDP adopted the toolkit as one of its official monitoring mechanisms to gauge the progress and maturity of Fayda's implementation.

Since then, Fayda has experienced rapid growth, with over 42 million total registrations reported and integrations with over 130 agencies. To take stock of how the Fayda ID system is evolving alongside adoption, NIDP employed the Digital ID Assessment in 2026 for a follow-up self-evaluation. This case study draws on both self-assessments to share what NIDP learned – and what changed between them.

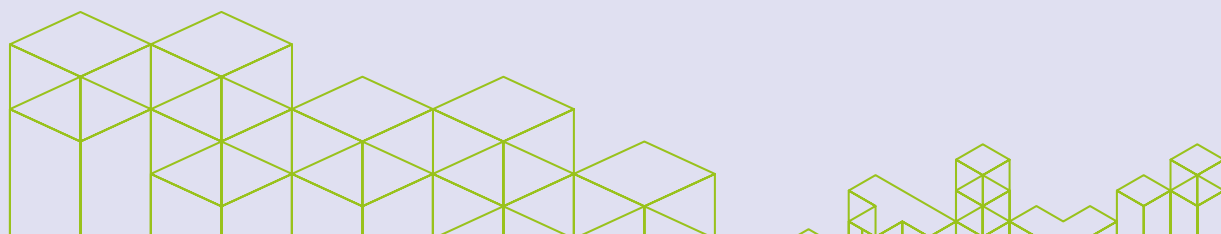
Use of the Digital ID Assessment

Originally conceptualized as a point-in-time self-evaluation, NIDP is now proving that the Digital ID Assessment can also serve as a monitoring tool. Beyond tracking Fayda's evolution and assessing informed implementation maturity over time, the toolkit guides more informed decision-making, supports operational learning, and strengthens internal accountability.

Repeated application also creates an institutional record of progress, challenges, and key learning moments – one that can be revisited to better understand how Fayda has matured. This serves NIDP's own long-term improvement journey while contributing to practical insights for other countries pursuing similar digital ID pathways.

Realizing that value, however, depends on how the Digital ID Assessment is run. Across both applications, NIDP took deliberate steps to set the self-evaluation process up for success.

1. Firstly, NIDP intentionally engaged multiple internal teams, including at on-site meetings, both at the beginning of the project and later to review the results. Equally important, NIDP had an assigned team to manage and run the self-assessment. In addition, one-on-one review sessions were conducted with the teams involved to go through the findings in detail, validate responses, and help ensure that self-evaluations were conducted consistently and in line with the assessment guidelines.
2. Secondly, NIDP required open, transparent answers to all evaluation questions to both establish an accurate baseline and measure progress against it. In parallel, they made



the strategic decision to collect and document evidence underpinning their responses. As a final step prior to sharing the self-assessment results, higher management held a meeting to review the responses and relevant evidence. This approach not only built internal awareness of the findings but also reinforced the credibility of the results and the meaningful progress demonstrated against the baseline.

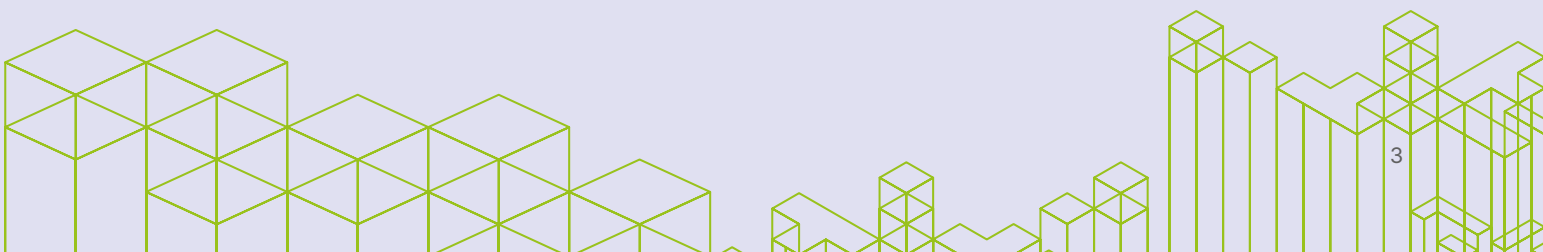
3. Thirdly, NIDP did not treat the second self-assessment as a symbolic exercise. Instead, they deliberately invested time, resources, and sustained attention to repeating the Digital ID Assessment as part of a broader commitment to continuously improving the Fayda ID system. While their first self-assessment provided valuable point-in-time insights, NIDP recognized the added value of repeat application to track system maturity and responsiveness to the country's evolving needs and growing adoption.
4. Lastly, following the first self-assessment, NIDP established an action plan to address identified gaps in order of priority – underway again for the second application – helping translate findings into targeted operational and institutional improvements over time.

The improvement journey

The initial application of the Digital ID Assessment in early 2025 produced NIDP's first structured, evidence-backed picture of the Fayda ID system. This was its most important function: not to grade the system, but to record where Fayda stood at a defined point in time, with documented evidence behind each response, so that future change could be measured against it.

The baseline showed a system with clear operational strengths – efficiency in service delivery, well-documented operational processes, and good data accuracy. It also identified specific areas where targeted attention was needed, in particular, capacity building, process strengthening, internal communication, and user experience ([refer to the first Fayda report](#) for more information). Together, these findings gave NIDP a clear starting position from which to prioritize actions and track progress over time. Examples of actions include:

- ▷ **Process improvements:** NIDP made continued investments to mature and formalize the processes used in the running and administration of Fayda ID system. These included strengthened internal management practices, alongside improved documentation and supporting tools, evidence tracking, and coordination workflows across teams – all of which contribute to improvements in organizational efficiency and delivery.
- ▷ **Communications improvements:** The above-mentioned process changes were supported by improvements to internal communication channels and coordination tools. This had the added benefit of increasing and improving both internal collaboration and institutional knowledge management across teams. Communications improvements have extended to the public with efforts, alongside broader awareness-raising and sensitization initiatives, helping strengthen the overall system performance and residents' experience of Fayda.
- ▷ **End-user services improvements:** NIDP made improvements to the end-user portal, used by residents, that allows for better online tracking of the status of resident-initiated service requests, including improved grievance reporting and remediation services. In turn, this provides important feedback from residents that can be used to improve the quality of the services provided.



- ▷ **Data protection improvements:** NIDP enacted enhanced approaches to operational oversight, and more structured procedures around enrollment, authentication, and integration with service providers. This included the development and enforcement of stricter policies for handling sensitive data, alongside improved protocols for data updates, sharing, and authentication-related usability.
- ▷ **Improved monitoring and metrics:** NIDP made improvements to the monitoring and metrics in multiple areas of the Fayda ID system, such as strengthening registration kit tracking, which helps ensure both operational security and the proper handling and protection of resident data and organizational assets. The trusted handling of both physical devices and identity-related information is key for building and maintaining trust and accountability. Additionally, these measures are critical to maintaining system integrity and reducing operational and security risks and strengthening accountability, especially in a distributed operational infrastructure that includes partner locations.

When NIDP drew on the Digital ID Assessment again in April 2026, the follow-up registered these investments as measurable gains against the 2025 baseline – most clearly in user experience, internal communications, and the policies and processes governing sensitive data, organizational security, and internal accountability. Several of the areas that had been flagged for targeted attention in 2025 were those that moved.

Across both cycles, the Digital ID Assessment has functioned for NIDP as more than a checklist. It has served as a structured way to set a baseline, prioritize action against it, and verify that the action produced measurable change – closing a loop that point-in-time evaluations can leave open. The picture that emerges across the two cycles is of a system doing two things in parallel: scaling rapidly in reach and maturing in the institutional practices that make that reach trustworthy. Sustaining both is what continuous improvement looks like in practice.

Key takeaways

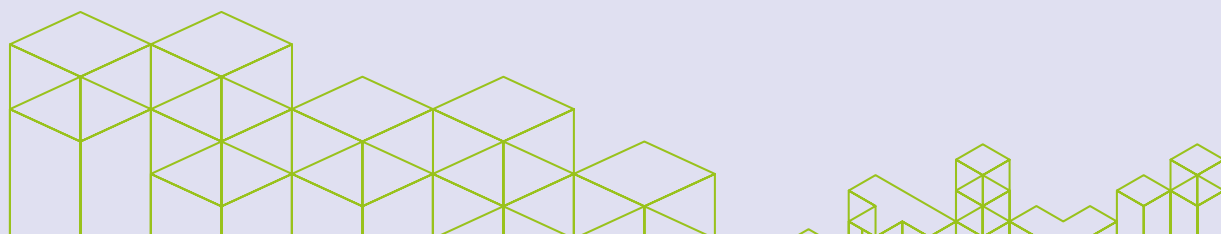
NIDP's experience developing and evolving Fayda can be informative for other countries on their digital ID journeys. Key learnings and takeaways from Ethiopia's use of the Digital ID Assessment include:

1. Simultaneous improvement and growth are possible.

Ethiopia has shown that even while under the strain of explosive growth, improvements to the systems were still being made. It is not, nor should it be, a "one or the other" situation. The lived reality of those using the system will continue to shift over time as a digital ID system continues to interact with the surrounding ecosystem in new and exciting ways. Therefore, having a two-prong strategy is necessary to ensure the system and processes can handle the evolving needs.

2. Strive to set higher standards of evaluation.

As systems and processes become more well understood and stronger, it allows those governing and running those systems and processes to take a more mature and critical view based on experience. As such, the standards and expectations to which the systems and processes are held should be improved – thereby continuing to set a higher bar for performance and outcomes.



3. Rapid growth is not handled equally well across systems and processes.

Rapid growth can strain the systems and processes unequally. This is especially true as limited resources are redeployed to support the most “critical” parts of the system during such growth stages. While the decision to do so makes logical sense in terms of making sure the systems and processes stay up and running, it does create “debt”, both technical and operational, which will need to be addressed at some point. It is important to track these situations to make sure they do not lead to a larger problem in the future.

4. Early engagement supports proactive improvement

NIDP’s repeated use of the self-assessment helped strengthen organizational awareness of evolving operational and governance needs, allowing improvements to be identified and addressed proactively as the system scaled.

Recommendations for other countries

If your country is considering using the Digital ID Assessment, NIDP’s approach shows how valuable it can be as a practical tool for reflection and learning – providing a clear picture of where your country is and what to do next, based on your own context. To maximize the value of the Digital ID Assessment, recommendations include:

▷ **Use repeat assessments as a reflective and longitudinal learning tool.**

Repeated application of the self-evaluation can help programs track institutional evolution over time, understand how systems and processes have matured, and identify recurring operational and governance lessons that can inform future improvements.

▷ **Create deliberate space to step back and look at the system.**

When managing a critical national system that serves millions, it is natural to focus on operational metrics that keep services running. Indicator-based self-evaluations, such as the Digital ID Assessment, provide a valuable opportunity to pause, reflect, and assess whether systems and processes are evolving in line with their intended purpose – and to track progress over time amid constant operational, both internally and externally.

▷ **Document and operationalize key implementation learnings.**

Capturing lessons, process adjustments, and institutional experiences across self-assessment cycles can help strengthen internal decision-making, support continuity as programs scale, and provide practical insights for other countries pursuing similar digital ID implementation pathways.

▷ **Leverage quick wins to build momentum.**

Identify and implement low-complexity, high-impact improvements early on to demonstrate value, build stakeholder confidence, and create buy-in for more complex reforms.

▷ **Recognize no single tool is sufficient on its own.**

The greatest value comes when the self-evaluation is embedded within a broader, multifaceted continuous improvement approach. Pairing indicator-based results with complementary practices – such as root cause analysis and structured stakeholder dialogue – helps translate findings into clear, prioritized actions. This combination supports more



transparent decision-making and ensures that identified gaps lead to meaningful, targeted improvements in the next cycle.

▷ ***Consider seeking diverse perspectives.***

While the Digital ID Assessment centers on the digital ID system, expanding the purview to consider the perspectives of diverse stakeholders – such as civil society, the private sector, and citizens themselves – will enrich any assessment process and strengthen the system’s continuous learning and adaptation over time.



Leverage the Digital ID Assessment in your context.

Whether you are looking to improve a more mature digital ID or get a steer on designing and launching your digital ID system, the Digital ID Assessment can help you. Get in touch via info@dial.global

